

Foreword by Stan Lee

It had to happen.

They were too mighty, too powerful, too popular! Every comic book fan had the same demand: "You must team them up! You must let them become Earth's Mightiest Team!"

Well, you know us. Your wish is our command. And so the Avengers was born.

In the beginning, we started slowly. Our first Avengers lineup consisted of Thor, Iron Man, Ant Man/Giant Man and the wondrous Wasp. But we couldn't wait to see the fireworks that would ensue if we added the Hulk and Sub-Mariner. And, of course, tossing in Captain America to lead the team was a no-brainer.

I loved the idea of having Iron Man's Fifth Avenue mansion become their headquarters. You wouldn't believe how many Marvel Comics fans, upon visiting New York, would immediately head for Fifth Avenue, desperately trying to find the mansion, hoping to get a glimpse of one of the Avengers, just as I used to search Baker Street when I visited London; certain I'd run into Sherlock Holmes and Dr. Watson sooner or later.

Of course, as time went by, some Avengers temporarily left the team while others were added. In fact, after the first few months, I had to keep referring to a list on my desk telling me who was a member at any given time because I couldn't keep track of them.

I guess almost every Marvel hero has been an Avenger at some time or other, but how about those great villains! Any team that has to fight the likes of Baron Zemo and his Masters of Evil, or Ultron, or Doctor Doom, or Kang the Conqueror, or the Mandarin, or Attuma, or Magneto—hey, you get the idea.

Of course, it was always fun to make good guys out of bad guys and vice versa, as in the case of Quicksilver and the Scarlet Witch. But I got the biggest kick out of the times when the group wouldn't be able to agree on who the next leader should be.

The thing is, when you run down the roster of Marvel's top heroes you've gotta realize it isn't an easy choice!

We certainly weren't bashful about including the fair sex, either. Who can forget the beautiful and exotic Enchantress, the Black Widow, Hellcat, Ms. Marvel, Tigra, Spider-Woman, Morgan Le Fey, Crystal, She-Hulk and the many other scintillating female characters whose fans will hate me because I forgot to mention them here. But, even though I may have forgotten a few, there's no way *you'll* forget them because you'll soon be feasting your eyes on each and every one on the *pandemonious* pages that follow!

One of the more interesting things about the Avengers is that every decade or so we get a whole new take on Earth's mightiest team. The original Avengers of the 1960s gave way to the new and different ones of the 1970s who, in turn, morphed into the Avengers of the 1980s. This team then transformed itself in the 1990s, until finally we have the new and exciting group that Marvel has gifted us with today.

But no matter how eloquently I describe the grandeur and glory of the Avengers, I can't begin to do justice to the wonderment you'll find in this book. So settle back and let your love of fantasy and adventure savor the magic and mystique of Earth's Mightiest Hero Team.

Excelsior!

Stan Lee

